SAMPLE

Worlds Beyond Earth: Miranda

Uranus's Broken Moon

Aira Astralis

Free sample: Introduction & Chapter 1
putrabooks.github.io

Introduction

Of all the worlds that circle the planet Uranus, none is stranger than Miranda. It is a small moon - so small that it would sit comfortably inside the borders of a large country on Earth - yet its surface tells a story of violence and change that seems far too big for a body its size. Deep canyons slice across its face. Vast cliffs drop away into darkness. Patchwork regions of grooved and ridged terrain sit beside ancient, cratered plains like pieces of a puzzle that do not quite fit together. When the Voyager 2 spacecraft flew past Uranus in January 1986 and sent back the first clear pictures of Miranda, scientists stared at the images in disbelief. One of them remarked that Miranda looked as though it had been taken apart and put back together the wrong way.

That first impression captures why Miranda matters. This little moon, only about 470 kilometers across, has become one of the most intriguing puzzles in planetary science. How did such a small world - too small to hold much internal heat, too small for the kind of volcanism that reshapes larger moons - come to have a surface so fractured, so young in places, and so unlike anything else in the Uranian system? The answers scientists have proposed involve shattering impacts, hidden oceans, and a delicate gravitational dance with neighboring moons that may have warmed Miranda's interior billions of years ago.

This book is an introduction to Miranda: what it is, how it was found, what we have learned about it, and the questions it still holds. We will begin with the story of its discovery in 1948, when astronomer Gerard Kuiper spotted a faint point of light beside Uranus. From there we will explore the moon's basic nature - its size, its orbit, its seasons of endless day and night. We will look closely at its spectacular surface features, including Verona Rupes, a cliff so tall that a rock dropped from the top would fall for several minutes before reaching the bottom. We will follow the only spacecraft ever to visit - Voyager 2 - through its brief but historic encounter. And we will look ahead to the future, when a new mission may at last return to Uranus and reveal the rest of Miranda's face, the three-quarters of the moon that no spacecraft has ever photographed.

Miranda also offers a window onto bigger ideas. It is a natural laboratory for understanding tidal heating, the process by which gravity can knead a moon's interior and keep it warm. It is a clue to the history of the entire Uranian system, with its strange sideways tilt. And it is a reminder that in the study of worlds, size is not destiny. Small moons can hold some of the solar system's largest secrets.

The journey through this book follows Miranda from its discovery to the mysteries that guide tomorrow's research. Like the moon itself, the story is full of surprises - a moon named for a character in a play about a magical island, that turned out to be an island of marvels of its own.

Chapter 01: The Discovery of Miranda

The discovery of Miranda was a triumph of patient, careful astronomy. To understand how difficult it was to find, it helps to picture what Uranus looks like through a telescope. By the twentieth century, astronomers knew that Uranus had moons - the two largest, Titania and Oberon, were discovered by William Herschel himself in 1787, just six years after he found the planet. Two more, Ariel and Umbriel, were spotted by William Lassell in 1851. But whether Uranus had any smaller satellites remained an open question for nearly a century.

The problem is that Uranus is far away - roughly nineteen times farther from the Sun than Earth - and its light is faint. Any small moon orbiting close to the planet would be even fainter, drowned in the glare of Uranus itself. Finding such a moon required a large telescope, sharp imaging, and a deliberate search. The astronomer who took on this challenge was Gerard Kuiper, one of the great planetary scientists of the twentieth century. Kuiper had already made his name with discoveries across the solar system; he would later have an entire belt of icy bodies, the Kuiper Belt beyond Neptune, named in his honor.

In 1948, Kuiper was working at the McDonald Observatory in Texas, home of the 2.1-meter Otto Struve Telescope, then one of the largest telescopes in the world. He turned the telescope toward Uranus and examined the neighborhood of the planet using photographic plates. Close beside the planet, he found a faint point of light that had not appeared in earlier searches. After confirming that the object moved with Uranus rather than being a background star, he announced the discovery of a fifth moon. It was the first moon of Uranus found in nearly a hundred years, and it remains the last moon of Uranus to be discovered by telescope - every Uranian moon found since was discovered by spacecraft or by space telescopes.

The new moon was designated Uranus V at first, following the numbering system used at the time. But Kuiper, like

other discoverers of Uranian moons before him, drew on literature for a name. The moons of Uranus have a naming tradition unlike any other planet's: instead of figures from Greek and Roman myth, they are named after characters from Shakespeare's plays and from Alexander Pope's poem "The Rape of the Lock." Titania and Oberon come from "A Midsummer Night's Dream." Ariel and Umbriel appear in Pope's poem, and Ariel later found a place in Shakespeare too.

For the fifth moon, Kuiper chose the name Miranda - the young heroine of Shakespeare's "The Tempest," daughter of the magician Prospero, raised on an enchanted island. It was a fitting choice. In the play, Miranda beholds the visitors to her island and marvels: "O brave new world, that has such people in it!" The moon that carried her name would prove to be a brave new world of its own, full of wonders that no one could have guessed from a single faint point of light.

After the discovery, astronomers spent nearly four decades learning what little they could about Miranda. Its brightness told them it was small - a few hundred kilometers across. Its orbit, worked out over years of observations, placed it closer to Uranus than any of the other four major moons, circling the planet in less than a day and a half. But a small, dim object two billion kilometers away is almost beyond study from Earth. Astronomers could track where Miranda was, but they could say very little about what it was. Whether its surface was young or old, icy or rocky, smooth or broken, remained unknown. The moon waited for a visitor.

That visitor was already being built. In 1977, NASA launched Voyager 2 on a grand tour of the outer solar system. The spacecraft's path would carry it past Jupiter, Saturn, and Uranus, with a final encounter at Neptune. At Uranus, Voyager 2 would come closest to the planet on January 24, 1986 - and its cameras would sweep across Miranda, giving humanity its first real look at Kuiper's mysterious moon. The discovery of Miranda in 1948 had opened the story; the flyby of 1986 would turn the page.